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An essay is, generally, a piece of writing that gives the author's own [argument](#), but the definition is vague, overlapping with those of a [letter](#), a [paper](#), an [article](#), a [pamphlet](#), and a [short story](#). Essays have been sub-classified as formal and informal: formal essays are characterized by "serious purpose, dignity, logical organization, length," whereas the informal essay is characterized by "the personal element (self-revelation, individual tastes and experiences, confidential manner), humor, graceful style, rambling structure, unconventionality or novelty of theme," etc.

Essays are commonly used as [literary criticism](#), political [manifestos](#), learned [arguments](#), observations of daily life, recollections, and reflections of the author. Almost all modern essays are written in [prose](#), but works in [verse](#) have been dubbed essays (e.g., [Alexander Pope's An Essay on Criticism](#) and [An Essay on Man](#)). While brevity usually defines an essay, voluminous works like [John Locke's An](#)

Essay Concerning Human Understanding and **Thomas Malthus's An Essay on the Principle of Population** are counterexamples.

In some countries (e.g., the United States and Canada), essays have become a major part of formal **education**.^[2] Secondary students are taught structured essay formats to improve their writing skills; **admission essays** are often used by **universities** in selecting applicants, and in the humanities and social sciences essays are often used as a way of assessing the performance of students during final exams.

The concept of an "essay" has been extended to other media beyond writing. A **film essay** is a movie that often incorporates documentary filmmaking styles and focuses more on the evolution of a theme or idea. A **photographic essay** covers a topic with a linked series of **photographs** that may have accompanying text or **captions**.